PARADISE FOUND

The disillusionment with urban living is driving ambitious new property developments offering all mod cons far away from the city



BROOKS ARTHAUS
Bhimtal, Uttarakhand
Area of entire development: **3 acres**
Area of houses: **1,400-3,500 sq. ft**
Price: **Rs 1.25-2 crore**



TATA MYST
Kasauli, Himachal Pradesh
Area of entire development: **12 acres**
Area of houses: **253-3,009 sq. ft**
Price: **Rs 75 lakh (starting price)**

According to Nilanjan Bhowal, principal architect at Design Consortium India, the demand for second homes has doubled since the pandemic. "Second homes were earlier a statement of opulence, a symbol of luxury. Now people have realised that investments in second homes away from the metros give much better returns. Second homes are more reasonably priced compared to a similar property in the metro. When not being used by the owners, second homes can be easily put on Airbnb because these days people prefer staying in smaller villas in quaint locations rather than big hotels. So, they are a good investment option. Plus, one can go and enjoy a stay with their family whenever they want," says Bhowal.

The growing demand for such properties is also evident in how major real estate developers are now offering second homes in Tier 2 and 3 towns. Bhowal's firm has designed a premium gated community, Brooks Arthaus, in Bhimtal, Uttarakhand; Tatas have set up eco-friendly villas in Kasauli, Himachal Pradesh; DLF has residential offerings in Shimla and Kasauli in Himachal and Goa; and the Mahindra and Hiranandani Groups both have luxury villa projects in Alibaug.

Nitish Mukherjee, 63, and his wife invested in a second home in Brooks Arthaus a year and a half ago. What really surprised him about their new home, says Mukherjee, was how much his 30-something son and his wife took to the property. While he and his wife moved to Bhimtal for a better quality of retired life, his children, employed in corporate jobs, have enjoyed working from the home in the hills. "We still have an independent house in Delhi but increasingly we are spending more time in Bhimtal. This is also due to the fact that the place has much better connectivity today than before. This doesn't mean that we don't face problems such as torrential rain, floods and so on, but overall, we are happier and feel more productive there," says Mukherjee. The couple enjoy connecting with villagers and feel they are able to give back to society more in Bhimtal than they could in the city. "We have always lived in urban settings and, for a while, were looking for a space where we could have a stronger sense of community, as well as be able to fit in exercise as a natural part of our daily life as opposed to by going to a gym." The pandemic was not the reason for the Mukherjees to spend more time in their second home, but it did make them aware that time is fleeting.

Bhowal says he has observed similar sentiments among many people. "Covid has made people realise that one must live life to discover oneself in harmony with nature. One can live sustainably amid lush green meadows and hills and experience life beyond just working for a living in the city," he says.

Today, many middle-class individuals and families are also investing in second homes. "I have a long-term rent arrangement with a cottage owner in Dharamshala. I pay only Rs 15,000 a month for a 2BHK property with a garden—one-fourth of what a similar home costs me in Delhi," says Abhirup Roy, a 39-year-old engineer who shifted from the NCR to Himachal Pradesh late last year.

Some suburban collective projects also make the proposition of a second home more affordable by dividing the cost between a group of people. WeCommunities, a brand of Vivasv Infra, in Bengaluru and Rajasthan, for example, specialises in sustainable living collectives where like-minded people can forge a deeper connection with nature. Individuals buy small portions of a farm as part of a collective, which together purchases a larger estate—around 80-100 acres—and convert it into a low-footprint, organic, farm with the necessary infrastructure. Members often buy homes near